

BLA3DE

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BLADE Process

Detailed Activity Guide

(90-Minute Version)

Welcome to the **BLA3DE**, the *Balanced Leadership, Allocation and Assignment, Democratic Engagement* process. This is structured around a “knife fight” metaphor for democratically forming balanced project teams. Will you make the cut!?

This isn’t about actual conflict, but rather a spirited, transparent process where 60 contributors will self-organize into 24-30 project teams through open negotiation, voluntary participation, and community decision-making. Drawing from open source values of collaboration and democratic participation, BLADE ensures everyone gets heard, teams are fairly balanced, and no one gets forced into a project they’re not excited about. Think of it as participatory democracy meets team formation - with just enough competitive energy to keep things engaging while maintaining the collaborative spirit that makes open source communities thrive.

Total Time: 90 minutes (no breaks) **Participants:** ~60 people forming 24-30 teams **Preparation Required:** Pre-work survey and Tech Lead briefing

Pre-Work Requirements

“Weapons Check” Survey (Due 48 hours prior)

All participants complete online form declaring:

- Top 3 project preferences ranked by enthusiasm level
- Core technical skills with proficiency ratings (1-5 scale)
- Any prior software development experience
- Any “non-negotiable” constraints (time zones, technology preferences, etc.)
- One “secret weapon” - a unique skill or perspective they bring
- Availability level (hours per week they can commit)

Responses are provided to all Tech Leads 24 hours before the meeting.

Tech Lead Preparation

Each Tech Lead receives:

- Summary of participant preferences and skills for their project
 - Standardized project brief template including required team composition
 - 60-second pitch guidelines and timing requirements
 - Target team size with acceptable range
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Welcome & Stage Setting (5 minutes)

- Brief BLADE process overview
 - Explain the “knife fight” metaphor and democratic principles
 - Set expectations for energy and participation
 - Quick logistics (movement, timing, etc.)
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B+L - Balanced Leadership & Allocation (35 minutes)

“Choose Your Fighter” (20 minutes)

Tech Leads deliver exactly 60-second pitches in random order. Each pitch must include:

- Project mission and impact (15 seconds)
- What makes this project exciting/unique (15 seconds)
- Specific skills needed and team composition goals (15 seconds)
- Leadership style and team culture vision (10 seconds)
- Memorable tagline or rallying cry (5 seconds)

Logistics:

- Strict time enforcement with visible countdown timer
- Random order drawn from hat to prevent sequence bias
- No Q&A during this phase - questions happen during deployment
- Tech Leads encouraged to be passionate and authentic

“Initial Deployment” (15 minutes)

Participants physically move to designated project areas around the room. Tech Leads act as active recruiters, facilitating conversations about:

- Day-to-day project work and expectations
- Team dynamics and collaboration style
- Growth opportunities and learning potential
- Realistic time commitments and project timeline

Key Rules:

- People can move freely between areas
 - Tech Leads can recruit but cannot pressure
 - Focus on honest conversations about fit and expectations
 - Visual feedback helps identify popularity imbalances immediately
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A - Assignment (30 minutes)

“Tactical Recon” (15 minutes)

Teams that are significantly over or under capacity (± 2 people from target) engage in structured problem-solving:

Over-capacity teams:

- Identify members who might thrive elsewhere
- Share honest assessment of workload distribution
- Connect with under-capacity teams that need their skills

Under-capacity teams:

- Clearly articulate what roles they need filled
- Highlight unique opportunities and growth potential
- Make compelling case for why someone should join

Neutral facilitators (pre-assigned volunteers) help broker conversations and ensure no one feels abandoned or pressured.

“Prisoner Exchange” (15 minutes)

Single round of structured negotiations focusing on:

Voluntary Transfers (8 minutes)

- Individuals announce desire to switch teams
- Teams can offer to “release” members who might be happier elsewhere
- All moves must be enthusiastic and voluntary

Strategic Swaps (7 minutes)

- Teams negotiate skill-based exchanges with individual consent
- Focus on creating stronger overall team compositions
- Emergency solutions for severely imbalanced teams

Democratic Safeguards:

- All negotiations happen in public view
 - Individuals retain absolute veto power over any proposed moves
 - Focus on mutual benefit rather than filling quotas
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D - Democratic (20 minutes)

“Ceasefire Negotiations” (10 minutes)

Rapid-fire town hall with strict time limits:

- 30-second statements only
- Focus on community good and specific proposals
- No rebuttals or arguments - just information sharing
- Common topics: skill gaps, workload concerns, enthusiasm mismatches

Facilitation:

- Pre-assigned timekeeper with visible countdown
- “Parking lot” for issues that can’t be resolved in this timeframe
- Emphasis on solutions, not just problems

“Treaty Signing” (10 minutes)

Each team conducts final confirmation process:

Team Huddles (5 minutes) Teams quickly confirm:

- Everyone genuinely wants to be there
- Team composition feels balanced and viable
- They’re excited about working together
- They understand and accept project scope

Final Ratification (5 minutes) Teams vote by show of hands (or secret ballot if requested) on whether to accept their final composition. Teams that vote “no” get 3 minutes for final adjustments before revoting.

Democratic Guarantee: Every individual gets final veto power over their placement, and every team collectively decides whether they’re ready to move forward.

Post-Event Activities (Within 48 Hours)

E - Engagement: “Victory Celebration” & “Post-Battle Alliance”

“Victory Celebration” (Asynchronous + Optional Virtual Meeting) Each team creates and shares their “battle cry” via shared workspace:

- Team name and mission statement
- Team member introductions with roles and excitement points
- One specific goal they’re committed to achieving
- Memorable team motto, chant, or rallying cry
- Optional: creative video, image, or presentation

Optional 30-minute virtual celebration where teams can present their battle cries live to the community.

“Post-Battle Alliance” (Asynchronous Collaboration) Teams use shared online workspace to:

- Map available skills and resources across teams
- Identify collaboration opportunities and shared components
- Establish code review partnerships and knowledge-sharing sessions
- Create mutual support networks for common challenges
- Plan cross-team learning sessions and resource sharing

Continuous Engagement

- 48-hour post-meeting survey to confirm satisfaction with placements
- One-week team health check to identify any early issues
- Monthly cross-team collaboration review

Facilitation Notes

Critical Success Factors:

- Strict time management with visible countdown timers throughout
- Pre-assigned neutral facilitators to help with negotiations
- Clear democratic safeguards at every step
- Emphasis on voluntary participation and mutual benefit
- Energy management - keep pace high but not frantic

Backup Plans:

- “Emergency protocols” for teams that can’t reach consensus in time
- Alternative project options for people who can’t find good fit
- Process for handling late arrivals or technical difficulties
- Pre-designated “floating” facilitators to help with bottlenecks

Democratic Values Maintained:

- Transparency in all decision-making
- Individual autonomy preserved throughout
- Community benefit prioritized over individual preferences
- Voluntary participation with genuine enthusiasm as the goal
- Post-event engagement ensures no one feels left out of team building

Energy and Pacing:

- No breaks means maintaining high energy throughout
- Physical movement during deployment helps prevent fatigue
- Variety in activity types keeps people engaged
- Post-event activities allow for deeper relationship building without time pressure

Technology Requirements:

- Visible countdown timers for each phase
- Shared digital workspace for post-event activities
- Optional video conferencing setup for virtual victory celebration
- Survey platform for follow-up check-ins